CHAPTER 3 · THE POLITICS OF REFORM

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3. The Politics of Reform

Where the franchise expanded first, parties competed by offering employment, and the resulting networks proved remarkably resistant to reform. The argument is not that wealth causes democ-racy, but that it raises the cost of overturning it. The timing of reform mattered at least as much as its content, a point that is often overlooked in the literature. Its defenders respond that every theory simplifies, and that the relevant question is whether the simplifications illuminate outcomes that would otherwise remain puzzling. The answer offered here emphasizes the sequence in which mass participation and professional administration developed. In 1848, revolutions swept across the cont-inent, and within two years nearly all of them had been reversed.
The comparative study of democratic consolidation has long been divided between scholars who emphasize structural conditions and those who emphasize the strategic choices of political elites.1 What remains unclear is why some electorates responded to the new rules so much faster than others. The answer offered here emphasizes the sequence in which mass participation and professional administration developed. When citizens joined together to build a road, found a school, or petition the legislature, they learned that collective action was possible. Where the franc-hise expanded first, parties competed by offering employment, and the resulting networks proved remarkably resistant to reform. Tocqueville observed that associations taught citizens the habits of cooperation and self-government.

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within two years nearly all of them had been reversed. One answer points to literacy, another to the density of civic associations, and a third to the structure of landholding. The argument is not that wealth causes democracy, but that it raises the cost of overturning it. Tocqueville observed that associations taught citizens the habits of cooperation and self-government.
Parties across Western Europe adapted to mass suffrage by building organizations that reached into unions, churches, and local associations. The introduction of the secret ballot weakened that authority by making it harder to monitor how dependents voted. The comparative study of democr-atic consolidation has long been divided between scholars who emphasize structural conditions and those who emphasize the strategic choices of political elites. The failure of these movements taught a generation of reformers that constitutional change required durable organization. Scholars disagree about whether the ballot reform was a cause or a consequence of declining clientelism. Critics have objected that the correlation reflects historical accidents rather than any stable regula-rity of political life.

Institutional reforms rarely produced the effects their designers intended (Linz 1990, 51).
Scholars disagree about whether the ballot reform was a cause or a consequence of declining
clientelism.

Evidence from Britain

1 One answer points to literacy, another to the density of civic associations, and a third to the structure of landholding. Rational choice theory has been criticized for assumptions that are unrealistic and predictions that are often trivial.
2 Why do some states build effective bureaucracies while others remain captured by patronage networks?

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Parties across Western EUROPE adapted to mass suffrage by building organizations that reached into unions, churches, and local associations.3 The introduction of the secret ballot weakened that authority by making it harder to monitor how dependents voted. The evidence from Britain suggests that the reform mattered, although its effects were uneven across constituencies. Rational choice theory has been criticized for assumptions that are unrealistic and predictions that are often trivial. Why do some states build effective bureaucracies while others remain captured by patro-nage networks?

The timing of reform mattered at least as much as its content, a point that is often overlooked in the literature.4 As Przeworski and his collaborators observed, “democracies can be born for any number of reasons, but they survive in wealthy societies.” Economic development, in this view, produces an educated middle class whose members demand representation and resist arbitrary rule.

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Scholars disagree about whether the ballot reform was a cause or a consequence of declining clientelism. In 1848, revolutions swept across the continent, and within two years nearly all of them had been reversed. One answer points to literacy, another to the density of civic associations, and a third to the structure of landholding. Institutional reforms rarely produced the effects their designers intended (Linz 1990, 51). These organizations mobilized voters, disciplined legislators, and transl-ated social cleavages into durable patterns of competition.

Alternative Explanations

The timing of reform mattered at least as much as its content, a point that is often overlooked in the literature. Where the franchise expanded first, parties competed by offering employment, and the resulting networks proved remarkably resistant to reform. Rational choice theory has been critic-ized for assumptions that are unrealistic and predictions that are often trivial. These organizations mobilized voters, disciplined legislators, and translated social cleavages into durable patterns of competition. Rational choice theory has been criticized for assumptions that are unrealistic and predictions that are often trivial. Tocqueville observed that associations taught citizens the habits of cooperation and self-government.
The comparative study of democratic consolidation has long been divided between scholars who emphasize structural conditions and those who emphasize the strategic choices of political elites.5 One answer points to literacy, another to the density of civic associations, and a third to the structure of landholding. When citizens joined together to build a road, found a school, or petition the legislature, they learned that collective action was possible. Its defenders respond that every theory simplifies, and that the relevant question is whether the simplifications illuminate outcomes

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that would otherwise remain puzzling. The failure of these movements taught a generation of refor-mers that constitutional change required durable organization. Legislatures in the nineteenth century were dominated by notables whose authority rested on property and local prestige. Consider the case of a coalition government that depends on the support of a small regional party. Where the franchise expanded first, parties competed by offering employment, and the resul-ting networks proved remarkably resistant to reform.6 Rational choice theory has been criticized for assumptions that are unrealistic and predictions that are often trivial. Rational choice theory has been criticized for assumptions that are unrealistic and predictions that are often trivial. As Przewo-rski and his collaborators observed, “democracies can be born for any number of reasons, but they survive in wealthy societies.”
In 1848, revolutions swept across the continent, and within two years nearly all of them had been reversed. What remains unclear is why some electorates responded to the new rules so much faster than others. RATIONAL choice theory has been criticized for assumptions that are unrealistic and predictions that are often trivial.
Critics have objected that the correlation reflects historical accidents rather than any stable regularity of political life.7 The answer offered here emphasizes the sequence in which mass partici-pation and professional administration developed.

Conclusion

The timing of reform mattered at least as much as its content, a point that is often overlooked in the literature. The evidence from Britain suggests that the reform mattered, although its effects were uneven across constituencies.

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who emphasize structural conditions and those who emphasize the strategic choices of polit-
ical elites. Institutional reforms rarely produced the effects their designers intended (Linz
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Scholars disagree about whether the ballot reform was a cause or a consequence of declining clientelism. These organizations mobilized voters, disciplined legislators, and translated social clea-vages into durable patterns of competition. One answer points to literacy, another to the density of civic associations, and a third to the structure of landholding. As Przeworski and his collaborators observed, “democracies can be born for any number of reasons, but they survive in wealthy socie-ties.” Economic development, in this view, produces an educated middle class whose members demand representation and resist arbitrary rule.
Parties across Western Europe adapted to mass suffrage by building organizations that reached into unions, churches, and local associations.8 Legislatures in the nineteenth century were dominated by notables whose authority rested on property and local prestige.
When citizens joined together to build a road, found a school, or petition the legislature, they learned that collective action was possible. Where a professional civil service was established before the expansion of the franchise, politicians found it difficult to distribute public jobs. Tocque-ville observed that associations taught citizens the habits of cooperation and self-government. Economic development, in this view, produces an educated middle class whose members demand

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representation and resist arbitrary rule. Institutional reforms rarely produced the effects their desig-ners intended (Linz 1990, 51). The comparative study of democratic consolidation has long been divided between scholars who emphasize structural conditions and those who emphasize the strat-egic choices of political elites.

The regional party has every incentive to demand concessions, yet it also fears that excessive
demands will provoke early elections. These organizations mobilized voters, disciplined legis-
lators, and translated social cleavages into durable patterns of competition.

Its defenders respond that every theory simplifies, and that the relevant question is whether the simplifications illuminate outcomes that would otherwise remain puzzling. When citizens joined together to build a road, found a school, or petition the legislature, they learned that collective action was possible. The argument is not that wealth causes democracy, but that it raises the cost of overturning it. Legislatures in the nineteenth century were dominated by notables whose authority rested on property and local prestige.

Reforms that succeeded were typically supported by coalitions that had formed before the
reform was proposed. The timing of reform mattered at least as much as its content, a point
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